UPFRONT

GLASSHOUSE: ROUGH ROAD FOR ROACHES *PG 10*

ECOWATCH: KILLER HEAT AHEAD *PG 11*



TAKING STOCK Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis with farmers in Solapur district, Sept. 23

AGRICULTURE

THE DROUGHT DEFICIT

A volatile monsoon of intense rain and prolonged dry spells is deepening agrarian stress across large swathes of India

By SONAL KHETARPAL

THE WORST, IT SEEMS, IS COMING TO PASS. Across India, deficient monsoon rainfall, compounded by El Niño—the abnormal warming of the central and eastern Pacific Ocean—has left 51.2 per cent of the country's area facing drought conditions in the first nine months of 2026, with mounting stress on crops and farm incomes. This is nearly three times the area affected last year and two and a half times that in 2024. So, 100 per cent of Goa, 95.7 per cent of NCT of Delhi, 84.1 per cent of Maharashtra, 81.8 per cent of Sikkim, 80 per cent of Punjab and 76 per cent of Haryana and Telangana are said to be undergoing drought conditions, according to the India Drought Monitor, developed by the Water and Climate Lab at the Indian Institute of Technology Gandhinagar.

A drought year is defined as one in which the overall rainfall deficit exceeds 10 per cent and the area affected by drought conditions is more than 20 per cent. The India Meteorological